truly independent nation. But it was also a time when relations with Nepal deteriorated over the expulsion of ethnic Nepalese in the early 1990s, when Indian anger grew at the presence of insurgents from northeastern India who trained at camps in southern Bhutan, and when China began to show renewed interest in the Himalayan kingdom.

In the outside world, however, the fourth druk gyalpo became best known for promoting his entirely new development concept, the GNH instead of the Gross National Product (GNP). Along with the GNH came a vigorous campaign to strengthen national identity. Known as *driglam namzha*, it sought to promote the national language, Dzongkha, and citizens of both sexes were instructed to wear Bhutanese national dress rather than western-style clothing.

This was not an easy task, given the fact that Bhutan is actually ethnically very diverse for such a small, sparsely populated country. In broad terms, the population consists of four major ethnic groups, which in turn are made up of several subgroups. The Ngalops are people who migrated to Bhutan as early as the ninth century. The name means ‘earliest risen’ or ‘first converted’ and they are related to the Tibetans, embraced Buddhism at early stage in history, and speak Dzongkha as their mother tongue. The Ngalops live in western and northern Bhutan and are the dominant political and cultural group in modern Bhutan.[37]

The Sharchops (‘easterners’) live mostly, as the name implies, in eastern Bhutan and are of mixed Tibetan and South Asian descent. They are believed to have migrated into Bhutan from Assam or possibly northern Myanmar over the centuries. Because of their proximity to Assam, many of them speak Assamese or even Hindi, apart from their own Tshangla, which, like Dzongkha, is a Tibeto-Burman language. The Sharchops are closely related to the Monpa of the Tawang area across the border in India. Although the Sharchops comprise the biggest single ethnic group in the country, they have become assimilated into the Tibetan-Ngalop culture.

Then there are aboriginal tribal groups living in scattered villages throughout Bhutan. They are mostly Hindu and related to tribal groups in Assam. Some of these groups are considered the most indigenous of Bhutan’s various ethnic groups, while others are descendants of slaves who were brought to the country from similar tribal areas in India.

The fourth group consists of people of Nepalese origin. They are called Lhotshampas, meaning ‘southerners’, and most of them migrated to Bhutan